Mom from Another American: Asking and Telling

By Marc Wolf

MOM: **(Pg 604-608)** I knew that he hated it—and. . .that ship. And he wasn't-- matter of fact when he was home I think he really wanted to go AWOL but he really didn't want to get into trouble either and now I wish I would've never let him go to the airport. . .

INTRODUCTION

On October 27, 1992, Petty Officer Allen R. Schindler, Jr., 22, was brutally beaten to death in a public restroom in Sasebo, Japan, by two of his shipmates, Terry Helvey and Charles Vins. They beat and stomped Schindler to death because Schindler was gay. Their attack was so vicious that they destroyed every organ in Schindler's body. Allen Schindler's mother, Mrs. Dorothy Hadjys-Holman, could identify her son only by the remains of the tattoos on his arms. The medical examiner compared Schindler's injuries to those sustained by victims of a fatal airplane crash or a high- speed automobile accident - all but two of Schindler's ribs had been broken, his penis bore cut marks and his liver contained holes that allowed the pathologist to see straight through it. . .

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MOM: The night before Allen was killed he called me to tell me that his paperwork was gonna be there any day now and he'd be discharged and he'd be home before Christmas for good. And then 24 hours later they were at the door knocking at the door telling me he was dead.

Matter of fact, I had on one of those long night shirts? It was only 7:15 and I was home alone and I didn't expect nobody to come over so when I came home after I ate I just went and took my clothes off and put it on and was watching TV and they came to the door and any mother who has somebody in the service knows that if two guys come in dress blues that's something bad--and um they told me that Allen had been assaulted in a park in Japan and that he was dead and I sat here for about 45 minutes before I

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even realized I didn't have any clothes on. I was hysterical that night but compared to the night when they called me from California and told me I wouldn't want the coffin open?--that was the worst.

Until then I had no idea how he was killed you know I didn't know if he was shot or stabbed. At first I didn't even know it was Americans who killed him--shipmates. They were shipmates on the same ship—

The Navy did not tell me. Every time I would ask them they said they were looking into it. The Navy wouldn't tell me--they would never admit Allen was killed because he was gay. They they don't know why he was killed. Just that Terry Helvey was drunk. Terry Helvey kept giving different statements; everytime the wind blew he gave a different statement so they didn't know what to believe. And Charles Vins just kept his mouth shut. He wouldn't say nothing so he said that he would tell the truth if they would make a deal with him and not charge him with murder.

So that--after they made the deal...he told them you know what did happen. It wasn't until after the deal was made that he also told them that he also kil--kicked Allen three times. That he was an accomplice. I mean he served 72 days. You know I I cannot understand how someone can watch somebody get killed, even if he hadn't done anything--how he could stand there and watch happen what happened to Allen and do nothing--and then just be charged with failure to report a crime.

Terry Helvey's shoeprint was embedded in my son's face.

The whole time I waited for his body to return, I thought that um I would be able to hold him and I would be able to kiss him goodbye and then they told me that there was nothing that they could do to make him presentable and that I really should never open the coffin. My minister begged me not to open the coffin cause he had seen it and not to go in there and look at him but there was nothing that was gonna stop me

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from going to see him.

And I went in there and--and I couldn't hold that body. I mean it looked nothing like my Allen. It was nothing like my Allen. And then they closed the coffin and the whole day I thought how do I know it's him? I mean sure the hat's there and the uniform's there and it has his pin on it that says Schindler but how do I know it's him? And the next day during the wake that we had for him it just kept going through my mind. I'm gonna have to open up that coffin again. And I'm going I r...really I don't think I can do it. And just before the wake was over I went out in the hallway and I talked to my daughter Kathy and it was really funny cause she wanted to talk to me the same time I wanted to talk to her and we both wanted to say the same thing.

She wanted to say, "Mom, how do we knot that's Allen?" And so she agreed--her husband and her, that when everybody left they would reopen the coffin and they would roll up the sleeve and see if his tattoo was there. He had a shark on one arm and he had a tiger on the arm--other arm and he had the emblem of the USS Midway the ship that he loved on his arm but I was upset when he got the tattoo--you know, disformed his beautiful body you know but if it wasn't for that tattoo to this day I would not know that's him in that coffin...

If somebody could show me in the Bible where Jesus says--I don't mean Paul or anybody else but where Jesus says that I'm not to have anything to do with homosexuals, where I'm to condemn 'em because they're worthless and I mean that's the way I feel that a lot of these ministers make it seem like they're worthless. There's people out there like Jerry Farwell. I think if I could ever (BEAT) stand as close as I am to you with Jerry Farwell I would slap him in the face. I mean he just preaches so much hatred.

Allen's up in heaven. No matter what...those evangelical Christians think, I think Allen's in Heaven.

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D'you wanna hear something really weird? OK. I have a nephew who's--he's seven years old now so like he was only two and a half, three when Allen was killed, so he really doesn't remember Allen much. I mean he remembers a little bit about him. And then he, you know, from being on the news and everything like that but he believes that when he--if he has a balloon or something and it goes off up into the air then Allen catches it.

So a couple of weeks ago was my grandson's birthday and we had bought some helium balloons and there was some--two purple ones and Allen's favorite color was purple and so James was kind of acting up so I said "Well James why don't we go get the purple balloons and then we'll release them and let Allen catch 'em up in heaven." And it was real windy out and we went outside and we—

Him and my grandson were gonna release the balloons up in the air *[breath]* And they went flying off so far cause it was so windy. They went really way up and finally they got to the point that we couldn't see 'em, and the minute we couldn't see 'em like a storm came and I mean it came down like buckets just like that and it only lasted for a couple of minutes and then it was gone. Anybody'd think I'm really crazy but it was like Allen saying, "I caught it Mom."

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Marc Wolf
Book: Political Stages: A Dramatic Anthology (Emily Man & David Roessel eds)
Pgs 604-608
ISBN: 978-1557834904
Publisher: Applause Books
Date (Month/Year): May 2002

AWARDS

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